

THE INDIAN CONNECTION

# Opportunity Knocks

New Delhi is willing to repair the trust deficit with the new regime

**A**fter living under a charade of democracy foisted by the Musharraf regime, there seems to be a whiff of real democracy for Pakistan, which is good news for India. It may mean a new beginning for the stalled dialogue process. While most pundits may say that democratic regimes in Pakistan have not fared well on the issue of cross-border terrorism—Nawaz Sharif was the premier when Kargil happened in 1998 and Benazir Bhutto had authorised ISI's bleed India strategy—but conventional wisdom suggests that democracies do have an ear to the ground and tend to respect popular sentiment, which currently is in favour of better relations with India.

The hope in South Block is that the gains of a composite dialogue and people-to-people contacts would be far more visible under a democratic regime. For India it is important that a new beginning is made with Pakistan because continued hostility from across the border does have a bearing on its aspirations to play a larger role in the global arena, besides having an impact on its economic growth. A real signal, on the issue of curbing terrorism, will be from the new Pakistani leadership, where both Asif Ali Zardari's Pakistan People's Party and Nawaz Sharif's PML(N) will have a key role to play.

The new regime in Islamabad now has a choice—either embrace fundamentalism, or move away from it in favour of economic growth and strengthen ties with neighbours like India. The last few months have shown that the average Pakistani does not support militancy, which may influence the Government and the army to fine tune their policies on cross-border terrorism. An immediate impact of developments in Pakistan would be that the stalled peace process can finally begin. But the big question is, whether the little gains on main issues like Jammu and Kashmir can be taken forward.

Officials say India has maintained contacts with most key players in Pakistan, and even if Musharraf is ejected from the presidential seat it will be able to calibrate its moves in advance. "The Pakistani army will continue to play a dominant role and with its present occupation on the Western border I don't think that terrorist violence against India will go up, but the new regime may go back on the Kashmir formulation proposed by the Musharraf regime," says former Indian envoy to Pakistan G. Parthasarathy. South Block believes it should give the new regime a six-month breathing time to settle in and then test it on the issue of cross-border terrorism and handing over of Indian fugitives. Officials are aware that even as they engage Islamabad, they will also need to work in tandem with the US and Musharraf, if he continues as President. On the other front, New Delhi seems willing to repair the trust deficit that exists between the two sides and convince the new Pakistani government of the gains of a cooperative economic and political relationship. But this can only be pushed through a composite dialogue process, which badly requires acceleration.

by Saurabh Shukla

tion Ordinance (NRO) that granted immunity from corruption cases to former ministers and bureaucrats, including Zardari. The widower has continued to hedge his answers to the question of restoration of the judges, speaking instead of institutionally strengthening the "independence of the judiciary" for the future.

PPP and PML(N) are meeting in Islamabad with other victorious parties such as the ANP to hammer out a common agenda. The coming days hold the promise of a historic transition of power in Pakistan which the world, especially India, is watching for. All across Pakistan there is a new hope

**STALLED PEACE: Manmohan with Musharraf in New Delhi**



**India believes it should give the new regime six months and then test it on the issue of handling cross-border terrorism.**

that the democratic forces that have been swept to power would bring about the much-needed change. Democracy is the best revenge, as young Bilawal had wisely noted at his first press conference after his mother's death. Now it's important that, as visiting US Senator John Kerry, put it, "the grudges of the past are put aside because these elections are not about the past but about Pakistan's future." The onus now lies on the power duo to guide their country through this hour of crisis and change. ■